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KCFB KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

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2025: A Year of Resolve, Clarity, and Forward Momentum

2025 was a year that demanded steadiness. With the Tulare Lake Subbasin under unprecedented scrutiny and groundwater rules reshaping how we farm, Kings County Farm Bureau stayed focused on what matters most: protecting local agriculture, maintaining clarity for landowners, and creating space for honest conversations about the future.

The year began with continued uncertainty surrounding SGMA compliance and the State Water Resources Control Board's actions in Kings County. As the legal landscape shifted, KCFB provided a consistent flow of information to help landowners understand what was changing and what it meant. Members received timely updates through Farm Life, email alerts, and public statements that cut through confusion and delivered the facts. That commitment to clarity set the tone for the entire year.

When the Fifth District Court of Appeal issued its decision in late 2025, KCFB responded with the same resolve it has shown throughout this process. The Board of Directors voted to pursue review by the California Supreme Court and announced a fundraising goal to support the next phase of the SGMA Defense effort. That decision drew statewide attention and reinforced KCFB's

role as a central voice for agriculture in the Tulare Lake Subbasin. More than a dozen media outlets covered KCFB's work this year.

But 2025 was not defined by litigation alone. This year, KCFB partnered with the Kings County Economic Development Corporation to produce an agricultural economic impact report—an important tool that helps local leaders, agencies, and residents understand the scale and significance of agriculture in Kings County.

KCFB also strengthened collaboration across the community. In September, the organization launched First Fridays with Farm Bureau, a monthly in-person series designed to update growers on water issues and provide a forum for real conversations.

As the contracted administrator for the Excelsior–Kings River Resource Conservation District, KCFB supported day-to-day operations, producer outreach, and conservation program coordination across the district's service area in Kings, Fresno, and Tulare Counties.

In a year marked by legal shifts, regulatory pressure, and increasing public attention, KCFB stayed focused, stayed steady, and stayed connected to the people it serves.

SGMA Defense & Legal Advocacy

Inside the SGMA Battle: What 2025 Really Looked Like

Few issues have shaped Kings County agriculture as profoundly as groundwater regulation under the Sustainable Groundwater Management Act (SGMA). And in 2025, no organization carried a heavier load—or a clearer voice—than Kings County Farm Bureau. This was the year the legal battle accelerated, the policy impacts sharpened, and the statewide significance of the Tulare Lake Subbasin came fully into view.

This article is the clearest account of what happened, why it matters, and what KCFB did to stand up for the growers, families, and communities who depend on groundwater—and on fair governance of it.

A Turning Point: The Fifth District Court of Appeal Decision

In late 2025, the Fifth District Court of Appeal issued a published decision reversing the preliminary injunction KCFB had secured the previous year. That injunction had prevented the State Water Resources Control Board (SWRCB) from enforcing its probationary requirements in the Tulare Lake Subbasin. With the reversal, the SWRCB was once again able to proceed with its enforcement authority under SGMA, including reporting mandates, metering requirements, and potential fees.

This was a significant legal moment—not just for Kings County, but for every agricultural region in California facing SGMA compliance pressures.

SGMA Defense continued on page 2

KCFB
KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

Purpose
Protect, preserve and enhance agriculture in Kings County

Vision
Ensure that every farmer has the right to farm and protect their heritage

Values
Our Members | Proactive Representative
Reliable | Trusted Resource

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The published opinion immediately became part of statewide legal precedent, referenced by attorneys, agencies, GSAs, and growers in other basins evaluating their own exposure to state intervention.

The decision drew substantial media attention, with multiple outlets framing the ruling as a key inflection point for how SGMA would be enforced across California.

KCFB's Response: Steadfast, Immediate, and Public

When the Court of Appeal's decision was released, KCFB responded quickly and decisively. The Board of Directors voted to pursue review by the California Supreme Court—an action that required both urgency and long-term commitment. KCFB publicly announced its intention to continue the fight and established a fundraising goal to support the next phase of litigation.

Across all communications—*Farm Life* articles, email alerts, social media updates, and in-person discussions—KCFB reinforced the same message: the legal questions at stake extend far beyond Kings County. The case centers on how SGMA should be implemented, what due process looks like, and whether the state is obligated to honor the "good actor" provisions within the law. Those questions impact landowners and water districts from northern rice country to the Imperial Valley.

KCFB didn't escalate rhetoric; it escalated clarity. And in a moment where fear and speculation tended to fill the information void, clarity mattered.

Why This Case Matters — Locally and Statewide

The stakes of the KCFB lawsuit extend well beyond Kings County's borders. SGMA was written to give local groundwater agencies the primary responsibility to manage basins and correct deficiencies. The law contemplates state intervention only when those local efforts fail. KCFB's case challenges whether the SWRCB followed the statute's required process—and whether landowners were afforded appropriate notice, fairness, and consideration in the lead-up to probation.

Statewide implications include:

1. How far the SWRCB's authority extends in a probationary basin

The decision in the KCFB case shapes what the state can require—and how quickly it can require it—once a basin is placed on probation.

2. What "due process" means for agricultural landowners under SGMA

If landowners can be compelled to comply with state enforcement actions without individualized notice or an opportunity to be heard, every basin in California is affected.

3. Whether the state must account for "good actor" provisions

Many basins include growers who have invested heavily in conservation, recharge, or water-use reduction. KCFB's case raises the question of whether those efforts must be recognized under SGMA's implementation.

4. The future of local control

At its core, SGMA is built on local governance. The Tulare Lake Subbasin became the test case for defining the boundary between local planning and state intervention.

When reporters described the case as "one of the most important groundwater lawsuits in the state," they weren't exaggerating.

Keeping Members Informed and Prepared

Throughout the year, KCFB focused on one mission: make sure growers had the information they needed to navigate a fast-changing regulatory landscape.

Communication included:

- Clear, timely breakdowns in *Farm Life*
- Email alerts on reporting deadlines and legal developments
- Social media updates summarizing next steps
- Direct answers to member questions
- Presentations at First Fridays with opportunities for live Q&A
- Public statements that replaced speculation with verified facts

For many landowners, KCFB was the only reliable, neutral source explaining what the appellate ruling meant and what actions—if any—they needed to take.

A well near Corcoran pumps water into a standpipe. Lois Henry / SJV Water

Coordinating With Partners Across the Region

As the case moved forward, KCFB stayed in close contact with legal counsel, groundwater sustainability agencies, local organizations, and regional partners. This coordination ensured that growers could access updates not just about the lawsuit, but about basin-wide reporting obligations and compliance requirements.

In a year where the regulatory landscape changed quickly and repeatedly, KCFB's ability to stay connected to multiple agencies and partners was crucial.

Public Visibility: A Statewide Spotlight on Kings County

More than a dozen media outlets covered KCFB's legal battle in 2025. Coverage included:

- Regional agricultural news platforms
- Statewide investigative and policy reporting
- Agricultural radio, print, and digital media
- Water-policy news sites and professional analysis publications
- Legal-industry commentary tracking SGMA precedent

This level of coverage was matched only by the attention Kings County received during the 2023 flood, demonstrating again that local issues here can rapidly become matters of statewide focus when the stakes are high.

Across outlets, the framing was consistent: KCFB had become the central voice challenging the scope, process, and fairness of SGMA enforcement—an issue with implications in every agricultural basin in the state.

SGMA Defense continued on page 10

Media Coverage Year-in-Review

How California Watched Kings County: KCFB in the News in 2025

KCFB's work drew more public attention in 2025 than in any other year aside from the 2023 flood. As groundwater policy tightened and the SGMA-related legal battle accelerated, reporters across California looked to Kings County to understand what was happening—and why it mattered.

More than a dozen independent outlets covered KCFB's actions, the appellate court decision, and the broader implications for agriculture statewide. The result was a level of visibility that extended far beyond county borders and elevated the discussion about groundwater rights, local governance, and agricultural viability in California.

Local & Regional Reporting

Local coverage helped frame the story for residents, growers, and community leaders who were encountering SGMA's impacts firsthand. Regional agricultural news platforms provided context for how the appellate decision affected farmers, landowners, and groundwater agencies throughout the southern San Joaquin Valley.

These outlets focused on clarity: what changed, what the ruling meant, and how the legal process would proceed. Their reporting helped ensure the topic was accessible to readers who do not follow court proceedings or water policy closely.

Statewide News and Investigative Coverage

The statewide press treated the Tulare Lake Subbasin as a test case for SGMA enforcement. Reporters highlighted the statewide stakes: whether landowners were properly notified, how state intervention should work, and what the path forward might look like for basins currently on the brink of probation.

This coverage emphasized a key point that KCFB members already understood: the questions raised in Kings County are not limited to one subbasin. They influence how SGMA applies to growers from Redding to the Imperial Valley.

Statewide outlets also noted the economic dimension of the issue, referencing the significant role agriculture plays in the county's economy and the potential impacts of groundwater restrictions.

Agricultural Media Coverage

Agricultural media—print, radio, and digital—provided some of the clearest explanations of the legal process and the statewide consequences of the ruling. Multiple ag-sector platforms conducted interviews with KCFB leadership, allowing producers across the state to understand the legal questions from the perspective of a fellow agricultural community.

These outlets consistently framed Kings County as the leading voice for fairness, due process, and transparency within SGMA's implementation. Their reporting reached growers in other subbasins who were watching closely to see how the case might influence future state actions.

Water-Policy and Professional Analysis

Professional water-policy publications and legal-industry alerts offered technical analysis of the appellate decision and its significance for groundwater regulation. These pieces were widely circulated within government agencies, GSAs, law offices, and water associations.

Their analysis underscored how unusual the Tulare Lake Subbasin case is—highlighting procedural questions, enforcement timelines, and potential ripple effects for other groundwater basins that may face similar scrutiny.

This coverage solidified Kings County's role as a reference point for statewide SGMA debates.

What the Coverage Revealed

Across all outlets, several themes appeared repeatedly:

- The fight in Kings County raises statewide questions about due process.
- SGMA's enforcement mechanisms have broader implications than originally understood.
- The economic significance of agriculture in the Tulare Lake Subbasin gives the issue both regional and statewide weight.
- KCFB played a central role in articulating the concerns of landowners and agricultural producers.
- What happens next in this case could influence how SGMA is implemented in other regions.

For KCFB members, the volume and breadth of the coverage serves as a reminder that Kings County's challenges—and its leadership—are recognized far beyond the county line.

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Economic Impact Report

The Numbers Behind the Acres: The Kings EDC + KCFB Economic Analysis

In a year dominated by legal questions, regulatory deadlines, and shifting expectations under SGMA, one of the most important tools Kings County agriculture gained in 2025 wasn't a policy change or a court ruling. It was clarity.

To help bring that clarity into focus, Kings County Farm Bureau and the Kings County Economic Development Corporation partnered to develop an agricultural economic impact analysis—an effort designed to answer a single, essential question: *What does agriculture mean to the economy of Kings County, and what would be at stake if groundwater restrictions continue to tighten?*

In a region where agriculture is both a way of life and a cornerstone of economic stability, the need for credible, data-backed information has never been greater. The analysis provided exactly that.

Why the Report Was Needed

As SGMA enforcement intensified and the Tulare Lake Subbasin became the first in the state to enter probation, growers, agencies, and community leaders were all grappling with the same concern: decisions about groundwater use carry major economic consequences, but those consequences were rarely being discussed with precision.

The report addressed that gap. Rather than relying on broad statements or assumptions, the analysis quantified agriculture's role in the county's economy in practical terms—jobs, economic output, local supply chains, secondary impacts, and the broader influence agriculture has on businesses, services, public revenue, and community stability.

By grounding these conversations in verified data, the report helped shift discussions from speculation to substance.

What the Report Examined

The economic analysis captured the scope of agriculture's footprint in Kings County in several key areas, including:

- The direct economic contribution of crop and livestock production
- Employment tied to farm operations and agricultural services
- The role of agriculture-dependent industries—transportation, processing, equipment, and service providers
- The importance of agricultural exports to the regional economy
- Potential economic impacts tied to groundwater limitations or pumping restrictions

These categories were not theoretical. They reflected everyday realities for families, farms, and businesses across Kings County. By assessing the relationships between agricultural production and local economic vitality, the report provided a structure for understanding how water policy decisions ripple far beyond individual fields.

A Tool for Leaders, Agencies, and the Community

Throughout 2025, the report became a valuable resource for anyone trying to understand the broader context behind SGMA compliance and state intervention. Local leaders referred to the analysis when asking questions about what reduced groundwater pumping could mean for employment, tax revenue, or business sustainability. Agencies used it to help frame discussions about planning and long-term resilience. Community members cited it as a clear explanation of why the region's agricultural base matters not only to farmers, but to every resident and business in the county.

Because the analysis came from two trusted local institutions—KCFB and Kings EDC—it carried credibility in a way that outside reports often do not. It was not written to advance a particular position; it was built to provide clarity.

Supporting a More Informed Conversation

The release of the analysis did not answer every question facing Kings County agriculture, nor was it intended to. Instead, it created a shared foundation of understanding at a time when decisions about groundwater policy were often being made without a full appreciation of the economic consequences.

For growers, it explained how their operations fit into the larger economic system.

For civic leaders, it illustrated the scale and interdependence of agriculture.

For residents, it highlighted how deeply the county's prosperity is tied to the ability to farm.

In community meetings, agency discussions, and public forums throughout 2025, the analysis helped bring the economic stakes into sharper focus. As SGMA-related litigation and policy debates unfolded, it allowed Kings County to speak with greater confidence about what was on the line.

A Foundation for the Work Ahead

The economic impact report will remain an important resource in 2026 and beyond. Its data will continue to support conversations with policymakers, regional partners, and community members as Kings County navigates the next phases of groundwater governance. And as the legal process continues, the analysis will help contextualize why KCFB's advocacy—and the clarity it provides—is so critical.

In a year defined by complexity, the economic report delivered something essential: **a clear view of what agriculture means to Kings County, and why it must be protected.**

The full economic impact analysis will be available at: www.kcfb.org/economicreport2025

First Fridays Launch

First Fridays Begins: A New Space for Straight Talk

In September 2025, the Kings County farming community gained something new: a simple, open space to meet, talk, and compare notes on the issues shaping daily life on the farm. **First Fridays with Farm Bureau** launched on September 5 with a clear purpose—not to lecture, not to preach, and not to deliver a one-way stream of information, but to bring growers, landowners, and community partners together around the same table.

The concept grew out of a year defined by tightening groundwater rules, a major appellate court decision, and constant questions about what the next season would bring. People wanted a place to hear what others were seeing, share what they were experiencing, and stay connected in real time. First Fridays became that place.

Each luncheon begins with a short briefing—just enough to set the stage for the discussion. The opening meeting covered the SGMA lawsuit, reporting expectations under probation, and the timelines unfolding at the state level. But what happened after the briefing mattered just as much. Conversations opened across the room, growers compared experiences, and questions turned into shared problem-solving.

From the start, First Fridays was designed as a two-way exchange. KCFB may provide factual updates, but the real value comes from what participants bring with them—their concerns, observations, ideas, and on-the-ground knowledge. Month by month, those discussions helped highlight what producers were struggling with, what information gaps existed, and where clarity was most needed.

Just as importantly, the events created opportunities to talk about the wins: successful recharge efforts, collaborative projects, new plantings, and the day-to-day resilience that doesn't always make it into policy conversations. In a year that often felt defined by regulatory pressure, First Fridays gave people room to talk about what was going right, too.

The lunches quickly became a place where KCFB could **listen as much as it spoke**, shaping future communication based on what was heard in the room. Questions raised at First Fridays made their way into Farm Life articles, email alerts, and follow-up conversations with agencies and partners. The events helped ensure that KCFB's work stayed grounded in the real-world experiences of the people it represents.

At its core, First Fridays is not a program. It's a gathering. A touchpoint. A chance for the community to show up for each other during a complicated year. And as 2026 approaches, that purpose remains unchanged: create a space for honest conversation, shared learning, and a stronger sense of connection across the agricultural community.

SGMA DEFENSE FUND

Join the Fight!

THIS EFFORT HAS SAVED GROWERS IN THE TULARE LAKE SUBBASIN $40-$60/ACRE AND $300/WELL SINCE KCFB WAS ISSUED A PRELIMINARY INJUNCTION.

CONTRIBUTE $15/ACRE TO THE SGMA DEFENSE FUND

KCFB + EKRCD Partnership

Strengthening Local Agriculture: KCFB's Work With EKRCD

Behind every successful conservation district is a great deal of coordination, organization, and day-to-day work that most people never see. In 2025, Kings County Farm Bureau continued its role as the contracted administrator for the **Excelsior–Kings River Resource Conservation District (EKRCD)**, supporting the district's mission across its service area in **Kings, Fresno, and Tulare Counties**.

EKRCD's work touches some of the most important agricultural and environmental challenges in the region—soil health, water resources, conservation planning, program participation, and producer education. KCFB's responsibility was not to run those programs itself, but to make sure the district had the administrative backbone needed to function smoothly for the growers and landowners who rely on its services.

A Partnership Built on Practical Needs

Resource conservation districts operate with lean structures and wide mandates. They coordinate grants, support conservation practices, convene meetings, and help producers connect to programs that can improve water use, soil health, and long-term land stewardship.

KCFB's role in 2025 was straightforward but meaningful: keep the district organized, responsive, and accessible. As the contracted administrator, KCFB handled the operational details that allow EKRCD to stay focused on its mission, including:

- Preparing board materials and supporting district governance
- Facilitating communication with landowners and partners
- Maintaining records and documentation
- Supporting project and program coordination
- Assisting with outreach around resource-related opportunities
- Ensuring the district's administrative obligations were met efficiently and on time

For growers, this work translated into a district that was easier to reach, easier to understand, and better equipped to communicate opportunities and program updates.

Supporting Conservation and Water-Resource Efforts

In 2025, EKRCD continued offering conservation-related opportunities aimed at improving soil health, supporting efficient water use, and helping producers stay aware of resource-focused programs available in the region. While the district's mission is broader than any single program year, several consistent efforts remained central to its work.

Through its administrative role, KCFB helped EKRCD maintain continuity and reliability across multiple activities, including outreach related to:

- **Soil-health improvement practices**
  Communicating opportunities for producers to learn about or participate in practices that improve soil structure, organic matter, and long-term field resilience. This included sharing general information about conservation tillage, cover crops, residue management, and other commonly adopted soil-building approaches.
- **Water-use efficiency and conservation considerations**
  Providing growers with updates about resource-efficiency programs, technical support opportunities, and general information related to irrigation improvements, water-management strategies, and best practices shared by regional partners.
- **Resource stewardship programs**
  Supporting awareness of broader conservation and stewardship initiatives that fall within the district's mission, such as habitat-related opportunities, rangeland resources, and general land-stewardship education offered through partner organizations.
- **Local producer information needs**
  Helping ensure that questions reaching the district—whether about district operations, resource programs, or general conservation inquiries—were documented, routed, and responded to in a timely and organized manner.
- **District events and collaborative activities**
  Assisting with administrative and communication support for meetings, workshops, and collaborative efforts involving partner agencies, conservation groups, and regional agricultural organizations.

These efforts did not replace the technical work performed by conservation specialists, state or federal partners, or program administrators. KCFB's role was to provide the administrative structure and communication capacity that helped EKRCD keep producers informed and connected to the opportunities available to them.

A Partnership That Benefits the Region

The KCFB–EKRCD partnership is not a symbolic collaboration; it is a practical one. By providing administrative strength to the district, KCFB helped reinforce an important piece of the region's agricultural support system. The district's visibility, responsiveness, and organizational stability are direct benefits to producers who rely on well-functioning resource institutions—especially in a year where water and soil considerations were at the forefront of nearly every decision on the farm.

The partnership also reflects a broader truth about agricultural communities: no single organization can carry the full weight of conservation, water management, communication, and compliance. When local institutions work together—each contributing their strengths—the entire system becomes more resilient.

Looking Ahead

The work KCFB supported in 2025 created a steady foundation for EKRCD's future projects and producer engagement. As the region continues to navigate groundwater constraints, conservation planning, and long-term resource needs, a strong, well-organized district will remain essential.

KCFB's administrative role will continue to focus on exactly that—ensuring the district has the operational capacity it needs to serve growers, support conservation efforts, and remain a reliable partner across Kings, Fresno, and Tulare Counties.

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Producer Support & Regulatory Clarity

Helping Growers Navigate a Moving Target

For producers across Kings County, 2025 was a year defined by shifting rules, complex reporting requirements, and the growing pressure of SGMA enforcement in the Tulare Lake Subbasin. Through it all, Kings County Farm Bureau focused on one core responsibility: **helping growers understand what was happening, what it meant, and where to find reliable information.**

The task wasn't simple. With the State Water Resources Control Board resuming its probationary oversight following the appellate court's decision, producers faced a steady flow of deadlines, notices, and evolving expectations. Many landowners found themselves attempting to interpret unfamiliar regulations or navigate reporting systems that were new even to longtime operators.

KCFB stepped into that environment not as an enforcer or a regulator, but **as a steady point of reference**—a place where growers could look for plainspoken explanations, verified updates, and direction on where to go for official information.

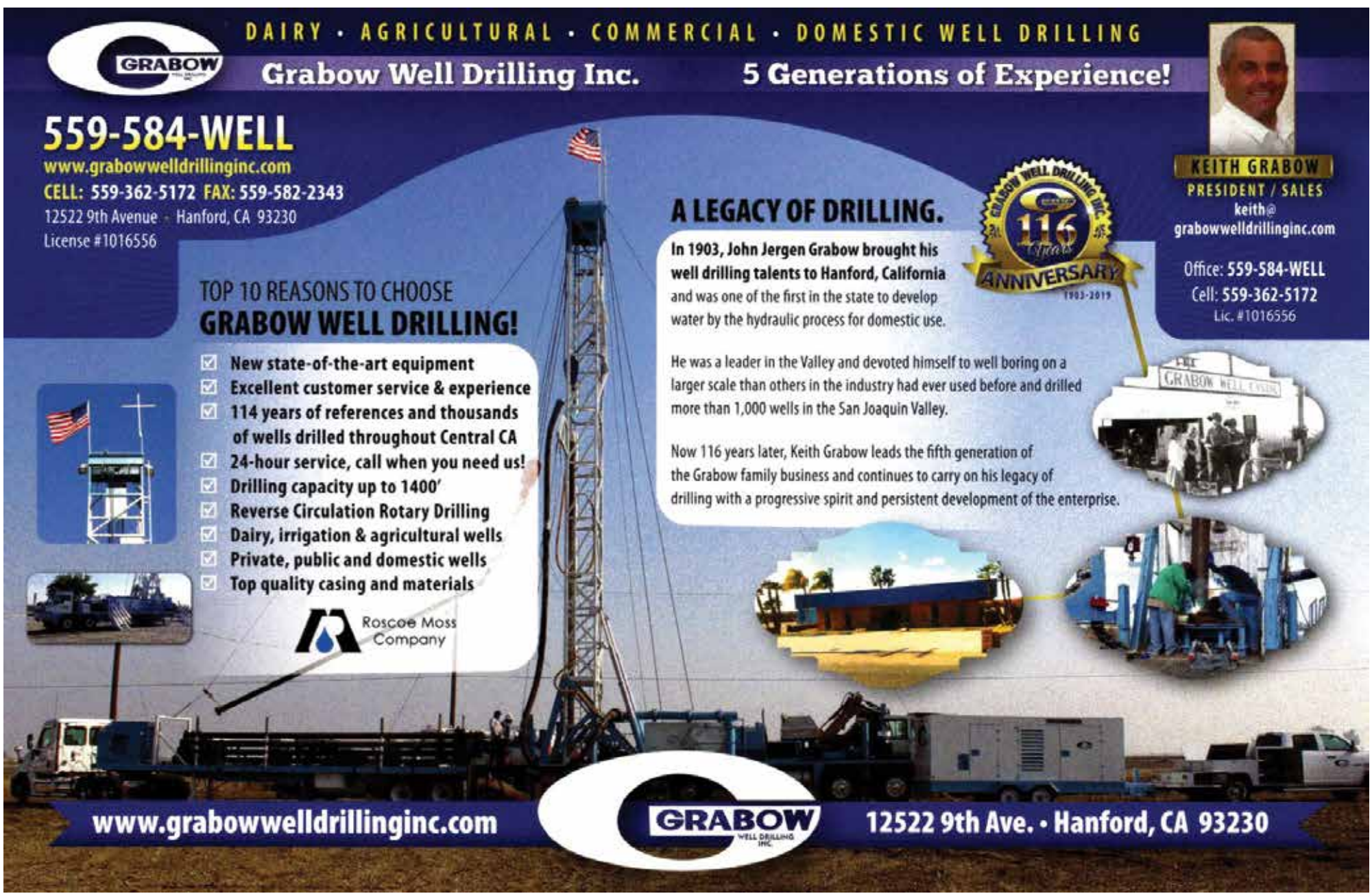
Clear Communication in an Uncertain Year

Throughout the year, KCFB focused on delivering information in formats that growers actually use. *Farm Life*, email alerts, and social updates worked together to keep producers informed without overwhelming them. Updates were designed to be specific enough to provide clarity but broad enough to remain accurate as the regulatory landscape evolved.

Key communication efforts included:

- Breaking down major SGMA developments
- Identifying upcoming deadlines or state requirements
- Providing links to official agency portals and

Producer Support continued on page 10



107th KCFB ANNUAL MEETING

Thursday, November 20, 2025 Tachi Palace Hotel & Casino

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A Year Defined by Resolve

2025 tested the agricultural community in ways few expected. Through every shift in the legal and regulatory landscape, KCFB remained steady. The organization did not overreact, underreact, or attempt to spin the situation. It focused on what producers needed most: facts, clarity, and representation.

The road ahead remains challenging, but the work done in 2025 built a stronger foundation for what comes next. KCFB enters 2026 aligned, prepared, and committed to seeing the legal process through with the same resolve that defined this year.

Producer Support continued from page 9

resources
- Summarizing public meetings and board actions
- Offering context for the appellate ruling and Supreme Court review decision
- Clarifying where growers should direct compliance questions

Each update served the same purpose: reduce confusion, avoid speculation, and keep the community grounded in confirmed information.

First Fridays as a Real-Time Feedback Loop

As discussed earlier in this issue, the launch of **First Fridays with Farm Bureau** quickly became an important venue for regulatory clarity. These meetings allowed growers to ask specific questions, share what they were encountering, and hear what others in the community were experiencing.

For KCFB, these conversations were invaluable. Questions raised at First Fridays directly informed the topics covered in subsequent updates and articles. For growers, the opportunity to hear from peers mattered just as much as the updates themselves. With so many rules tied to groundwater, pumping, reporting, and basin governance, having a place to compare experiences helped reduce confusion across the region.

Staying Connected to Agencies and Partners

Another essential part of providing clarity was maintaining active communication with the agencies shaping water policy. KCFB stayed in contact with legal counsel, groundwater sustainability agencies, district partners, and regional organizations throughout the year. These relationships allowed KCFB to understand what information was being released, what new questions were emerging, and how best to help landowners access accurate guidance.

The goal was never to stand between growers and official sources, but to make sure the community had a reliable pathway to them. Whether the information came from state regulators, GSAs, or legal representatives, KCFB's role was to help members locate the right documents, understand the context, and avoid misinformation.

A Trusted Source in a Complicated Year

The need for steady communication in 2025 cannot be overstated. With SGMA-related deadlines set by the state, a major appellate ruling, and a pending Supreme Court petition, growers needed clarity more than commentary. KCFB met that need by focusing on what it could provide with absolute confidence: factual updates, contextual explanations, and a consistent presence during a difficult year.

For many producers, the most valuable service was not a single article or meeting—it was knowing that when something changed, KCFB would be there to explain it. That trust was built through consistency, transparency, and a commitment to accuracy.

Looking Ahead

As Kings County enters 2026, the need for reliable communication will remain. Regulatory timelines will continue to evolve, legal processes will move forward, and growers will face decisions that depend on accurate information. KCFB will continue offering clear updates, helpful context, and opportunities for the community to ask questions and learn from one another.

In a year where the ground constantly shifted under growers' feet, clarity became more than a service—it became a necessity. And in 2025, that clarity was exactly what KCFB worked to provide.

Membership, Sponsorship & Organizational Strength

Steady Hands, Strong Voices: The Backbone of KCFB

In a year marked by legal uncertainty, rapidly changing groundwater rules, and an unprecedented level of attention on Kings County agriculture, one constant remained at the center of KCFB's work: the members, sponsors, and supporters who make the organization possible.

KCFB's strength has never come from the size of its staff or the scale of its budget. It comes from a community of people who believe in showing up for each other, staying informed, and supporting the work required to keep local agriculture represented. In 2025, that commitment showed up in ways big and small—through volunteer leadership, sponsorships, renewed memberships, event participation, and the steady flow of feedback that shaped KCFB's communication and priorities.

A Membership Built on Trust

Membership in KCFB has always been about more than a card or a mailing list. For growers, landowners, and ag-related businesses, it represents a shared belief that agriculture deserves a strong, credible voice—especially during years like 2025, when the policy environment demanded constant attention.

The value of membership became especially clear as the SGMA-related legal process unfolded. Members relied on KCFB for verified updates, context, and accessible explanations of regulatory developments. And while the organization worked to keep its communication timely and accurate, it was the trust of the membership that gave that communication meaning.

Producers who attended First Fridays, read *Farm Life*, asked questions, and engaged with the organization helped create a feedback loop that kept KCFB's work grounded in real-world needs. That engagement strengthened the organization as a whole.

Sponsors Who Keep the Work Moving

KCFB's sponsors played a critical role again in 2025. Their support helped sustain Farm Life, events, outreach materials, and communication efforts during a year defined by high information demand. As conversations about water, land use, and regulation intensified, the steady backing from local businesses and industry partners allowed KCFB to meet those needs without interruption.

Sponsorship is more than a funding mechanism. It reflects a shared commitment to local agriculture and to the institutions that support it. Many sponsors have deep agricultural roots themselves, and their involvement reinforces the broader community's connection to the work being done on behalf of growers and landowners.

A Year That Demonstrated Organizational Resilience

KCFB's ability to operate effectively in 2025—even as legal and regulatory pressures increased—was a direct reflection of its organizational resilience. Board members provided steady leadership. Volunteers stepped up at events and community meetings. Staff managed a heavy flow of communication and coordination with professionalism and consistency.

The organization's partnership with EKRCD further demonstrated this capacity. Taking on the administrative responsibilities of a multi-county conservation district highlighted KCFB's ability to manage complex workloads while still keeping member needs front and center. That administrative strength supported not only the district, but the broader agricultural community.

A Foundation for the Work Ahead

As 2026 begins, KCFB's greatest strength remains the people behind it. The organization's ability to communicate clearly, engage meaningfully, and represent agriculture effectively depends first and foremost on the members and sponsors who stand with it.

The year ahead will bring new questions, continued legal developments, and more conversations about groundwater, local governance, and long-term agricultural viability. But it will also bring opportunities—opportunities to strengthen community ties, expand engagement, and keep agriculture's voice strong in Kings County.

In 2025, KCFB's membership and sponsors didn't just support the organization. They shaped its work, informed its direction, and made it possible for KCFB to remain a steady voice during a complicated year.

That foundation is what will carry the organization forward.

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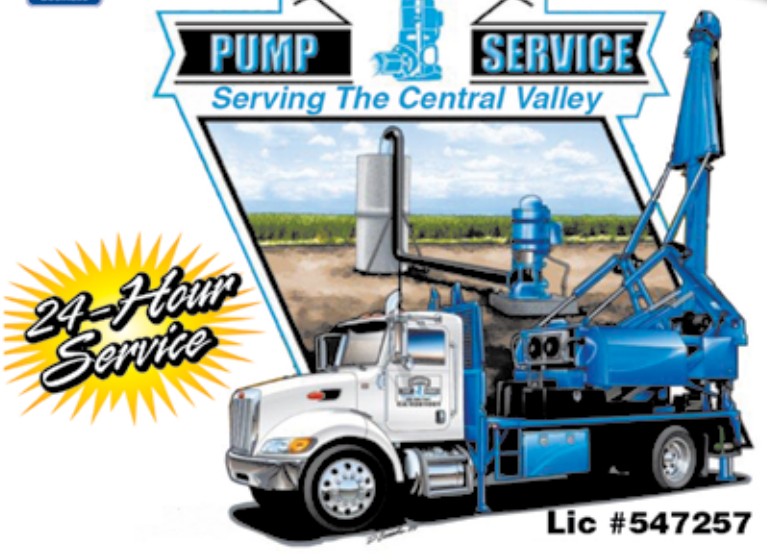

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Looking Ahead

The Road to 2026

As Kings County moves into 2026, the issues facing local agriculture remain as complex as ever. Groundwater regulation, SGMA enforcement, and the questions raised by the appellate court decision will continue to shape the conversations happening in fields, boardrooms, community meetings, and the courts. The next phase of KCFB's SGMA Defense effort—its petition for California Supreme Court review—will add another layer of attention to Kings County and to the concerns voiced by growers throughout the Tulare Lake Subbasin.

Through all of this, KCFB's role will remain the same: provide clarity, represent local agriculture, and stay connected to the community it serves.

In the year ahead, KCFB will continue offering timely updates as the legal process unfolds and as the SWRCB's probationary actions develop. First Fridays will continue to offer a space for in-person conversation, where growers can compare experiences, ask questions, and hear what others across the county are facing. Farm Life will continue to highlight the work being done on behalf of members, share updates from partner agencies, and tell the stories that shape agriculture in Kings County.

KCFB will also maintain its administrative support for the Excelsior–Kings River Resource Conservation District, ensuring the district has the capacity it needs to serve producers across Kings, Fresno, and Tulare Counties. As conservation programs evolve and new opportunities emerge, that partnership will remain an important part of the region's agricultural support network.

None of this work happens in isolation. Agencies, community organizations, local businesses, and individual growers all have a part in shaping the future of agriculture in the county. What 2025 demonstrated—more clearly than any

recent year—is that Kings County agriculture is strongest when people stay connected, stay informed, and stay engaged.

The work ahead will require the same resolve and collaboration that defined the past year. But with a clear focus, an active community, and a shared commitment to the future, Kings County agriculture enters 2026 with a strong foundation and a united voice.

Soil-Biodegradable Mulch Films: Insights from Field Research

Contributed by Manpreet Singh, Technology and Innovation for Small Farms Advisor, UC Kearney-REC, Parlier

Why Growers Are Looking Beyond Poly Mulch

Conventional polyethylene (PE) mulch has long been a staple in high value vegetable and berry production systems. It warms soil, conserves moisture, and suppresses weeds. However, its end-of-season removal and disposal can be labor-intensive and expensive. Soil contaminated PE mulch is rarely recyclable, and leftover fragments down into micro and nanoparticles, that persist in fields for years. Soil-biodegradable plastic mulch (BDM) films offer an alternative. These materials are designed to be tilled into the soil after harvest, where microbes convert them into carbon dioxide, water, and organic matter.

What Soil-Biodegradable Mulch Is (and Isn't)

Commercially available BDMs are made from blend of biodegradable polymers - derived from plants such as corn starch (PLA, PHA), and from petro-based polymers (like PBAT or PBS). In addition, BDMs contain various additives, to improve their properties and performance, including plasticizers. The key distinction is that true BDMs are meant to biodegrade in soil, not just fragment like "oxo-degradable" plastics.

How BDM Performs in the Field

Research trials across crops such as tomatoes, peppers, broccoli, melons, strawberries, and pumpkins, have shown that BDMs can provide weed control and yields comparable to PE mulch. It is important to select a BDM film with the appropriate thickness for the crop's growing season to ensure the film remains intact throughout the critical weed-free period. In heavy-fruit crops like pumpkin, mulch fragments can stick to fruit surfaces and affect market appearance. For fields with nutsedge pressure, note that both PE and plastic BDMs can be pierced; paper-based mulches often perform better for nutsedge suppression.

Degradation rates depend on temperature, soil moisture, and microbial activity. The warm conditions of the San Joaquin Valley favor faster breakdown once the film is tilled into the soil. However, real-world decomposition is slower than lab tests, so remnants may persist for more than two years before fully mineralizing. Short to medium term studies (up to four years) have found no significant effects of BDM use on soil health indicators such as pH, microbial activity, or organic matter. Unlike PE fragments, BDM residues continue to decompose over time and do not accumulate as microplastics.

Costs, Certification Status, and Next Steps

Rolls of BDM typically cost 2-3 times more than PE but may offset by savings from skipping plastic removal and disposal at the end of growing season. Washington State University's Mulch Calculator lets you plug in labor, disposal, and material costs to compare scenarios for your operation.

Organic Status: No commercially available plastic BDM is approved for certified organic production in the U.S. The National Organic Program requires BDM to be biobased determined using ASTM D6866 test; current products do not meet that requirement.

Trials are underway at the UC Kearney-REC in Parlier to evaluate BDM films under San Joaquin Valley conditions using strawberry as a model crop. If you're seeking an alternative to plastic mulch, testing BDM on a few beds can be a practical next step. For on-farm trial support or specific questions about BDMs, contact Manpreet Singh at mansing@ucanr.edu or 5596466535.

Groundwater Plans, Legal Deadlines, and a Basin in Motion

Five GSAs. One basin. As March approaches, the basin's legal, political, and water realities are colliding.

by Julie Martella

In the next few months, all five GSAs in the Tulare Lake Subbasin must submit revised groundwater sustainability plans (GSPs) to the State. These plans are intended to address the issues that put the subbasin on probation and demonstrate real progress toward long-term sustainability.

For the revised GSPs to be accepted, the State is looking for more than strong local policies. It expects the GSAs to demonstrate regional coordination, particularly in allocation methods, subsidence responses, and the protection of domestic wells.

That's where the real work is happening now.

What Is a Coordination Agreement?

Under SGMA, a Coordination Agreement is a legally binding document that outlines how multiple GSAs within a subbasin will work together to achieve sustainability. It includes things like:

- Shared data and monitoring standards
- Aligned timelines and measurable objectives
- A clear method for dividing the subbasin's sustainable yield
- Processes for dispute resolution and shared accountability

While each GSA submits its own plan, they must agree on these core components to avoid conflicting policies, or worse, penalties from the State.

The Path to Coordination

Despite different strategies and policy timelines, the five GSAs are meeting regularly, exchanging draft materials, and participating in basin-wide discussions.

Multiple agencies confirmed they are actively working to align allocation methods using 2022 pumping data as a common reference point. There's broad agreement that consistent, defensible metrics are essential to avoid future conflict or court involvement.

The Elephant in the Room: Differing Opinions

Coordination doesn't mean everyone agrees.

Currently, the GSAs use different allocation models. Some rely on historical pumping data to assign water, while others distribute it evenly across parcels. Some agencies have already implemented ramp-down strategies, whereas others are still preparing theirs.

These differences reflect real pressures: legal risks, community expectations, and the unique geography of each GSA. But they also create tension, especially when decisions in one area may affect water availability or aquifer pressure in another. The fact that these conversations are happening in public meetings, stakeholder workshops, and cross-GSA discussions is a sign of forward motion.

Why Coordination Matters

Water doesn't stop at jurisdictional lines. Neither do the impacts of overdraft, pumping, or subsidence. That's why coordination isn't just a requirement under SGMA; it's a safeguard for local flexibility.

Done well, coordination allows the subbasin to:

- Share and align data sources, maps, and models
- Minimize duplication or conflicting enforcement
- Protect landowners from contradictory groundwater rules
- Strengthen the subbasin's standing with the State and reduce the risk of probation

It's not easy. But it's necessary, and underway.

Happening Around the Subbasin

While coordination continues, each GSA is making key decisions locally, from allocations to mitigation. Here's a look at where things stand across the basin.

Mid-Kings River GSA (MKR) closed comments on its Groundwater Allocation Policy on December 1, clearing the way for Board approval on December 16. The policy includes language that applies the rules to all parcels, confirms allocation eligibility for tribal and tax-exempt lands, and allows future revisions as data evolves.

MKR's board has signaled intent to submit a revised Groundwater Sustainability Plan (GSP) by March 2026, in alignment with subbasin-wide deadlines, and staff are working to finalize implementation details to meet that timeline. The Stakeholder committee continues to meet regularly.

South Fork Kings GSA (SFK) also closed comments on its draft groundwater allocation and mitigation policies, clearing the way for board approval.

The Advisory Committee continues to meet regularly and has recommended that well registration penalties begin in March for landowners who have not complied. SFK is also in active communication with neighboring GSAs to coordinate monitoring, subsidence thresholds, and long-term implementation.

Tri-County Water Authority (TCWA) is advancing a full-scale revision of its Groundwater Sustainability Plan, with a complete draft expected by the end of 2025. The agency has confirmed that metered groundwater tracking will begin in 2026, marking a significant shift toward measurable implementation.

Staff are actively reviewing policy alignments with other GSAs in the subbasin, including recharge coordination and allocation modeling. TCWA has also maintained consistent participation in inter-GSA discussions to help finalize the Coordination Agreement ahead of the March 2026 deadline.

El Rico GSA rules and regulations are firmly established and available at www.elricogsa.com. Groundwater pumping data for Water Year Ended 09-30-2025 needs to be reported. Over 95% of all parcels and wells have been registered.

They continue to advocate for coordinated allocation methods and ramp-down timelines that reflect downstream impacts. The Board remains vocal about the need for alignment across the subbasin, especially regarding how groundwater use in upstream GSAs can affect their wells and infrastructure.

Southwest Kings GSA did not release public updates in November.

What Happens Next: The Revised Timeline

Each GSA is now working toward the same final deadline: submitting a revised Groundwater Sustainability Plan by March 2026. Over the next few months, a specific timeline is taking shape, as discussed and clarified during recent board and advisory meetings.

December

Public comment periods have ended, especially for draft allocation policies and well-mitigation programs. GSAs are also finalizing their Sustainable Management Criteria (SMCs) and updating the language to match what the State has already approved in Kern and Kaweah. Many boards plan to review these updates at their De meetings.

January

The SFK and MKR GSAs plan to hold votes to adopt their final policies. This includes finalized allocation numbers, enforcement tools, and recharge credit rules. January will also focus on confirming alignment across GSAs, especially where policies affect shared infrastructure or cross-boundary aquifers.

February

Outreach plans will be finalized, and the full GSP documents will be assembled. This is also when coordination agreements will be finalized.

March

All five GSAs must submit their revised GSPs by the March 30th deadline.

What You Need To Know

Right now, a lot is being asked of growers. New rules. New numbers. New acronyms. It's easy to tune out, especially if the process feels distant or hard to follow.

However, these policies are designed to benefit you. Outreach is ongoing so you're not left in the dark. But it only counts if you decide to get involved.

No one else can speak for your land, your wells, or your water use. That's why participation matters—not for compliance, but for clarity and control.

Here's how to stay in the loop:

- Make sure you're on the email list, or ask someone you trust to forward the key info to you.
- Follow your GSA's social media for updates, workshop dates, and simplified explanations. Attend a meeting or pop-up. Even if you don't say a word, being in the room changes things.
- Read at least one section of the draft plan. Focus on allocation, recharge, or wells, whatever matters most to you.
- Ask a question. Call the GSA office. Talk to a committee member. Submit a comment.

We know that local control only works when the local community shows up.

This is your moment to shape what happens next; not after the vote, not after the penalties, not after the decisions are made.

It starts now. And it begins with you.

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